burning passion to soaring spiritual hymns, there was no shade of human expression her vast repertoire left untouched—each piece calibrated to visual content and condensed into three minutes.

In another crucial respect, Lata enshrined the values of the modern Republic. Deeply spiritual herself, she remained wedded to India's secular ideal. So many of her close mentors and comrades—Noor Jehan, Dilip Kumar, Mohd. Rafi, Naushad Ali, Sahir Ludhianvi and Javed Akhtar, among others—were Muslim. Political leaders bent backwards to court her but she stayed aloof from politics.

Just occasionally her beliefs put her in a tight spot. When Imran Khan was building a cancer hospital in his mother's memory, he importuned her to give a charity concert to raise funds. "I will fill Lahore's biggest stadium if you come," he reportedly said. Lata was inclined to accept; she had never been to Pakistan and it would have been wonderful to see friends like Noor Jehan on home ground. When word of the proposed visit got out though, the Indian government was less than amused. It gently requested her to desist, arguing that her concert, among other concerns, would pose a security risk outside its control. Worldly professional that she was, she promptly backed off. "*Apni sarkar ke khilaaf main kaisey jaa sakti thi* (how could I go against my government's wishes)?" she later told me.

Hers was a multi-generational mandate over the hearts and minds of music lovers, so much so that no leader could dream of such a devoted constituency—one reason why politicians flocked in droves for her elaborate state funeral in Mumbai. For herself, Lata would have modestly uttered a few words of heartfelt thanks before disappearing into the wings. But in her mind, she would have admired the *intezaam*. ■

A WHITE FINCH **IN FLIGHT**

Lata Mangeshkar's voice embodied a specific feminine persona that came to fill Indian cinema







It was like lustral water, her voice. It made the body sacred...
Complex feelings arise, therefore, when you see Lata Mangeshkar in the fullness of her legacy—a complexity that her own voice did not hold. For, wasn't it the very antonym of complex, of everything difficult? Yes, it was light itself...and lightness of being. A singer such as Lata does not reside merely on the music shelves, to be turned to at the end of the day, after weightier matters are accounted for. She was the ambient soundscape of a whole time in history, filling out physical space. The turntable next to the posh divan, the transistor balanced on the migrant labourer's shoulder walking back from dust-laden construction sites, the evening bustle at the small-town nukkad shop selling meetha Banarasi paan, the trucker's lonely highway, those faraway uncles with flowers behind their ears tuning into Radio Ceylon in slanted-roof houses—she was everywhere. How do you grasp the elements of such an omnipresence?

First, a truism: the early Lata was the real Lata. That was the gossamer voice that floated over a bloodied Indian landscape in 1949 as she intoned the long introduction to Khemchand Prakash's *Khamosh Hai Zamana / Aayega Aayega*—an aural apparition that stilled the air, lulling weary minds into amnesia, inviting them into a soothing, spectral landscape, a cinematic metaverse. That's where we can see her beginning to be a formative element in the story of a nation, crucial to its identity formation. One that wiped clean the messy palimpsest of history and turned it pristine, as if with the subtle, sattvik elements proper to a purificatory rite—wispy incense smoke and sublimating camphor.

Artistes and aesthetes alike often pause on the distinction between classical and film singing. Classical vocalists, strangely, rarely manage a good film song. Could Lata have drifted in the opposite direction? Perhaps yes. In terms of the purely material aspects of vocalism, she